

HS 511: Translation Theory

Course Code	HS 511
Course Name	Translation Theory
L-T-P-C	3-0-0-3
Prerequisites	None
Intended for	Ph.D./Masters/B.Tech. (3rd and 4th year)
Mutual Exclusion	None
Approval	62nd BoA (Jan 2026)

Preamble

This course introduces students to the major theoretical developments in the field of translation studies starting from the initial linguistic approaches to the contemporary cultural, postcolonial, and gendered turns. Students will investigate how translation has evolved into a crucial, interdisciplinary field, moving beyond linguistics and literature to encompass politics, culture, science, and epistemology. The course will examine the influence of language, culture, power, and identity on translation, both as a practical activity and an academic discipline. The objective is to provide students with a deep understanding of core theories in the field and to critically assess translation's role in creating knowledge, establishing canons, and facilitating intercultural communication.

Motivation

Translation is not only a linguistic activity, but a complex negotiation across knowledge systems, power structures, and identities. The course traces the historical trajectory of translation theory, from classical debates on fidelity and equivalence to contemporary cultural, postcolonial, and feminist approaches. It reveals how knowledge travels across linguistic and cultural boundaries, influencing technological innovation and public perception, and demonstrates translation reshapes global discourse and policy. For doctoral students in English and Translation Studies, this course offers a theoretical foundation to contextualize their research within major frameworks - linguistic, cultural, postcolonial, and feminist - and come up with more complex, interdisciplinary methods.

Through readings, discussions, and conversations with practicing translators, students will come to understand translation not merely as a linguistic act but as an epistemological and political practice that actively constructs meaning, rather than merely transmitting it.

Course Outcomes

By the end of this course, students will be able to:

- Trace the historical trajectory of translation theory, moving from the classical ideas of equivalence to contemporary cultural and postcolonial perspectives and critically evaluate the major shifts that have shaped the discipline
- Understand translation as a cultural, political, and ethical act capable of shaping power relations rather than merely a linguistic transference.
- Critically analyse and evaluate translated texts or translation practices through theoretical frameworks including polysystem theory, postcolonial theory, and feminist theory.
- Relate theoretical concepts to real-world translation challenges, understanding the complexities faced by professionals in various fields.
- Develop an interdisciplinary perspective that connects translation theory with science, technology, development, ethnography, and literature.
- Develop theoretically-driven research or projects that leverage translation as a primary method for inquiry and interpretation.

Course Modules

- **Module 1: Introduction to Translation Studies:** (4 Hours) Topics:
 - Definition of translation: historical overview and key debates
 - Translation as a discipline: interdisciplinarity and scope
 - Types of translation: literary, technical, audiovisual, etc.
 - Translation as a social, political, and cultural act
 - A brief history of translation: from the Bible translations to the Renaissance and beyond
 - South Asian traditions: Bhakti translations, Persian-Sanskrit-Arabic exchanges, colonial era translation projects, vernacular renderings of classical texts
- **Module 2: Early Theories of Translation and Equivalence:** (4 Hours) Topics:
 - Early theories: Cicero, Horace, St. Jerome, and Luther's influence on translation practices
 - The concept of equivalence in translation: Nida's dynamic vs. formal equivalence
 - The concept of "word-for-word" vs. "sense-for-sense" translation
 - Translation in pre-modern and non-Western contexts
- **Module 3: The Linguistic Turn in Translation Studies:** (4 Hours) Topics:
 - The notion of meaning: source-text oriented models
 - The linguistic turn: the impact of structuralism on translation theory
 - Roman Jakobson's model of translation and the theory of equivalence
 - Semiotics and the relationship between language and meaning in translation
 - Catford and linguistic approaches
 - James Holmes and the formation of Translation Studies as an academic discipline
- **Module 4: Systems and Functionalist Approaches:** (5 Hours) Topics:
 - Itamar Even-Zohar's Polysystem Theory: translation as part of literary systems; center-periphery dynamics; canon formation
 - Gideon Toury's Descriptive Translation Studies (DTS): norms, target orientation, and descriptive methodology
 - André Lefevere's concept of rewriting and patronage
 - Theo Hermans and the Manipulation School: translation as a controlled cultural practice
 - Skopos theory (Reiss & Vermeer) and purpose in translation
 - Text typology and translation functions
 - Adequate translation in the functionalist model. Adequacy vs. accuracy
- **Module 5: The Cultural Turn and Translator's Visibility:** (4 Hours) Topics:
 - From linguistic to cultural paradigms (Bassnett & Lefevere)
 - Cultural equivalence and the rejection of linguistic equivalence
 - Theories of cultural transfer. Translating cultural references, idiomatic expressions, and values
 - Translation as rewriting, representation, and ideological negotiation
- **Module 6: The Invisibility of the Translator:** (3 Hours) Topics:
 - Venuti's critique of fluency and transparency
 - Translator's agency and ethics
 - Domestication vs. foreignization
- **Module 7: Postcolonial Approaches to Translation:** (6 Hours) Topics:
 - Translation and empire: Orientalism and representation
 - Translation as resistance and decolonization
 - Spivak's "Politics of Translation" and Niranjana's critique of colonial translation
 - Bhabha's hybridity and cultural negotiation
 - Postcolonial translation in South Asian contexts
- **Module 8: Translation and Gender:** (4 hours) Topics:
 - Translation and gender: feminist critiques of traditional translation theories
 - The role of the translator in challenging gender norms and stereotypes

- Power, voice, and subjectivity
- Gendered language and translation strategies for promoting gender equality
- **Module 9: Ethics, Technology, and Contemporary Debates:** (4 hours) Topics:
 - Ethics of translation: Berman, Derrida, and Pym
 - Untranslatability and linguistic hospitality
 - Technological advances: machine translation, CAT tools, and AI in translation. Ethical considerations in the use of technology in translation
- **Module 10: Translating Practice – Conversations with Practitioners:** (4 Hours)

Laboratory Modules

NA

Text Books

1. Bassnett, Susan. *Translation Studies*. 4th ed., Routledge, 2014.
2. Venuti, Lawrence, editor. *The Translation Studies Reader*. 3rd ed., Routledge, 2012.

References

1. Bassnett, Susan. "The Translation Turn in Cultural Studies." *Translation, History and Culture*, edited by Susan Bassnett and André Lefevere, Routledge, 1990, pp. 123–140.
2. Bassnett, Susan, and André Lefevere, editors. *Translation, History and Culture*. Routledge, 1990.
3. Berman, Antoine. "Translation and the Trials of the Foreign." *The Translation Studies Reader*, edited by Lawrence Venuti, 2nd ed., Routledge, 2000, pp. 284–297.
4. Bhabha, Homi K. *The Location of Culture*. Routledge, 1994.
5. Catford, J. C. *A Linguistic Theory of Translation*. Oxford UP, 1965.
6. Derrida, Jacques. "Des Tours de Babel." *Difference in Translation*, edited by Joseph F. Graham, Cornell UP, 1985, pp. 165–207.
7. Even-Zohar, Itamar. "Polysystem Theory." *Poetics Today*, vol. 11, no. 1, 1990, pp. 9–26.
8. Flotow, Luise von. *Translation and Gender: Translating in the 'Era of Feminism'*. St. Jerome, 1997.
9. Holmes, James S. "The Name and Nature of Translation Studies." *The Translation Studies Reader*, edited by Lawrence Venuti, Routledge, 2000, pp. 172–185.
10. Jakobson, Roman. "On Linguistic Aspects of Translation." *The Translation Studies Reader*, edited by Lawrence Venuti, Routledge, 2000, pp. 113–118.
11. Lefevere, André. *Translation, Rewriting, and the Manipulation of Literary Fame*. Routledge, 1992.
12. Munday, Jeremy. *Introducing Translation Studies: Theories and Applications*. 4th ed., Routledge, 2016.
13. Nida, Eugene A. "Principles of Correspondence." *The Translation Studies Reader*, edited by Lawrence Venuti, Routledge, 2000, pp. 126–140.
14. Nida, Eugene A., and Charles R. Taber. *The Theory and Practice of Translation*. Brill, 1969.
15. Niranjana, Tejaswini. *Siting Translation: History, Post-Structuralism, and the Colonial Context*. U of California P, 1992.
16. Pym, Anthony. *Exploring Translation Theories*. 2nd ed., Routledge, 2014.
17. Reiss, Katharina, and Hans J. Vermeer. *Towards a General Theory of Translational Action*. Translated by Christiane Nord, Routledge, 2014.
18. Simon, Sherry. *Gender in Translation: Cultural Identity and the Politics of Transmission*. Routledge, 1996.
19. Spivak, Gayatri Chakravorty. "The Politics of Translation." *Outside in the Teaching Machine*, Routledge, 1993, pp. 179–200.
20. Toury, Gideon. *Descriptive Translation Studies and Beyond*. John Benjamins, 1995.
21. Venuti, Lawrence. *The Translator's Invisibility: A History of Translation*. Routledge, 1995.